Where to Begin

By Cleo Wade

INTRODUCTION

Technology. Isn't it wonderful? We carry smart phones that alert us to the latest details of disease, disaster, and destruction, only one click away!

. . . . from a constant stream of anxiety-inducing information. (beat)

Whatever political beliefs we hold and whatever causes we support; we can all agree that we're living in a moment of grand-scale uncertainty. For some of us, our feelings are fuel for action. For others, it drives us to seek distraction or escape.

When the state of the world overwhelms you . . . take a moment, take a breath, and make a change.

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The world will say to you,

"Be a better person."

Do not be afraid to say, "Yes."

Start by being a better listener.

Start by being better at walking down the street.

See people.

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Say, "Hello."

Ask how they are doing and listen to what they say.

Start by being a better friend,

a better parent, a better child to your parents;

a better sibling, a better partner.

Start by being a better neighbor.

Meet someone you do not know and get to know them.

The world will say to you,

"What are you going to do?"

Do not be afraid to say,

"I know I can't do everything,

but I can do something."

Walk into more rooms saying,

"I'm here to help."

Become intimate with generosity.

Give what you can give and do what you can do.

Give dollars, give cents, give your time,

give your love,

give your heart, give your spirit.

The world will say to you,

"They are the enemy."

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Love enough to know
that just because someone disagrees with you,
it does not make them your enemy.
You may not win an argument,
you may not change a mind,
but if you choose to,
you can always achieve the triumph of radical empathy --
an understanding of the heart.

The world will say to you,
"We need justice."
Investigate.
Find truth beyond the stories you are told.
Find truth beyond the way things seem.
Ask, "Why?"
Ask, "Is this fair?"
Ask, "How did we get here?"
Do this with compassion.
See yourself in others.
Recognize that your justice is my justice,
and mine is yours.

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The world will say to you,
"I am violent."
Respond by saying,
"I am not.
Not with my words and not with my actions."

The world will say to you,
"We need to heal the planet."
Start by saying, "No, thank you. I don't need a plastic bag."
Recycle, reuse.
Start by picking up one piece of trash on your block.

The world will say to you,
"There are too many problems."
Do not be afraid to be a part of the solutions.
Start by discussing the issues.
We cannot overcome what we ignore.
The more we talk about things,
the more we see that the issues are connected
because we are connected.

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The world will say to you,
"There is so much hate."
Devote yourself to love.
Love yourself so much that you can love others
without barriers and without judgment.
When the world asks us big questions that require big
answers,
we have two options.
One: to feel so overwhelmed or unqualified, we do nothing.
Two: to start with one small act and qualify ourselves.

No one nominated Harriet Tubman to her purpose,
to her mission, to her courage.
She did not say, "I'm not a congressman
or the president of the United States,
so how could I possibly participate in the fight to abolish
a system as big as slavery?"
She instead spent 10 years making 19 trips,
freeing 300 people,
one group of people at a time.
Think about the children of those 300 people,
the grandchildren, the great-grandchildren and beyond.

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Our righteous acts create immeasurable ripples
in the endless river of justice.

Whether it's Hurricane Katrina, Harvey, Irma or Maria,
people did not say,
"There is so much damage. What should I do?"
They got to work on what they could do.
Those with boats got in their boats
and started loading in every woman, man and child they
came across.
We spend so much time
thinking we don't have the power to change the world.
We forget that the power to change someone's life is
always in our hands.
Change-making does not belong to one group of people;
it belongs to all of us.
You don't have to wait on anyone to tell you
that you are in this.
Begin.
We don't have to be heroes,
wear a uniform,
call ourselves activists

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or get elected to participate.

We just have to be brave enough to care.

I went to the birthday party of a man named Gene Moretti.

It was his 100th birthday,

which means he lived in the United States through the

Depression, World War II,

the struggle for workers' rights,

the achievement of a woman's right to vote,

the Civil Rights Movement,

a man on the moon, the Vietnam War

and the election of the first black president.

I sat with him, and I said,

"Gene, you have lived in America for 100 years.

Do you have any advice during these current times?"

He smiled and said to me simply, "Yes.

Be good to as many people as possible."

And as he danced with my mother,

in a room full of generations of his family

I realized that he had not just given me advice,

he had given me the first step

that every single one of us is capable of making

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if we want to create a real, wholehearted impact

on the world around us, right now.

"Be good to as many people as possible."

CLOSING

So today, I dedicate myself to embody the immortal words of Michael Jackson: ***(You may choose to sing to speak)***

I'm gonna make a change
For once in my life
Gonna make a difference
Gonna make it right

I'm starting with the man in the mirror
I'm asking him to change his ways
If you wanna make the world a better place
Take a look at yourself and then make a change

Won't you join me?

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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This poem was originally presented in 2017 as a TedTalk – the transcript can be found here:

https://www.ted.com/talks/cleo_wade_want_to_change_the_world_start_by_being_brave_enough_to_care/transcript

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